AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

AI Is Already in Your Team

How much AI use is already happening in my team?

MODULE 1 · LESSON 1 | WHAT JUST CHANGED | Awareness lesson · 4–6 min

THE CORE IDEA

AI entered teams before managers created structures to manage it.

AI use is almost certainly already part of how your team works — and your visibility into it is lower than you assume.

1 Your picture is probably incomplete

Ask yourself: do you have a real view of where AI is already shaping the work your team produces? Not whether people are interested in it, or have tried it — where it is actually shaping finished work. Most managers don't have that visibility yet. Not because they failed to pay attention: visibility is structurally hard to get, for two reasons.

2 The two reasons you can't see it

People rarely surface their own AI use

People use AI for drafting, summarizing, research, and writing help — through tools they find themselves. They don't announce it, and there has never been an expectation that they should. Your awareness tracks only the visible surface; the actual practice is broader.

The finished work doesn't show it

A report written with AI assistance looks like a report. A client email drafted with AI looks like a client email. AI does not announce itself in the end result — and this goes beyond unofficial tools. Approved tools, and the AI built into software the team already works in, leave no marker either. **It just looks like work.**

Put the two together — nobody surfaces it, and the work doesn't show it — and the picture will not correct itself on its own.

3 The scale of what's invisible

Microsoft and LinkedIn's 2024 Work Trend Index surveyed 31,000 knowledge workers across 31 countries. Three findings, each telling you something different:

75%
were using AI at work

78%
of those users were bringing their **own** AI tools to work

52%
were reluctant to admit using AI for their most important tasks

Microsoft & LinkedIn, Work Trend Index 2024.

These figures don't tell you what is happening in *your* team. They show why relying only on visible or formally announced use leaves a manager with an incomplete picture.

4 This has a name: Shadow AI

> **TERM – SHADOW AI**
> People using AI tools at work outside the formal systems, policies, or expectations of the organization.

It matters because it is the part of your team's AI use you cannot see – already shaping real work without appearing in any tool list, policy discussion, or team meeting. But in most teams, Shadow AI is not a story of bad intent. It is what happens when a useful technology arrives before the structures to manage it. People use what works. Some keep quiet out of worry it will reflect badly on them – but for most, it simply never occurred to them that their AI use was worth mentioning.

5 Asking directly changes the picture

Because the picture won't correct itself, direct questions often reveal a different reality from the one you thought you were seeing – how widespread the use is, how much real work it already shapes, and why you have never heard about it.

THREE QUESTIONS THAT SURFACE IT

1. Who has used AI at work in the last two weeks?
2. Who has used it for something significant – something that actually shaped a piece of work?
3. And who told me about it when it happened?

Caution: asking these openly only works where honest answers are already safe. Without that safety, start smaller – ask privately or in writing, and let people respond on their own terms. Module 2 builds the full method for getting this picture.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Treat your current picture of AI use as **partial by default** – visible and announced use is the surface, not the whole.
- Stop expecting the finished work to reveal AI involvement – it won't, even from approved tools.
- Read Shadow AI as a **structure gap, not misconduct** – the predictable result of tools arriving before structures.
- Shift the question from *"is AI use happening?"* to *"can I see enough of it to understand what has changed?"*

Module 1 · What Just Changed – this module builds the case for why managing AI use is now part of your role. **Next: Lesson 1.2 – The Mandate Without a Method** – why you're expected to lead this change without ever being handed a method for it.